EXERCISE 2

Write an outline of the passage below.

Obesity is a condition that results from excessive storage of fat in the body. It is now usually defined, using a formula known as the body mass index (BMI), in which weight (in kilograms) is divided by height (in meters) squared. It has been estimated that roughly two thirds of American adults are overweight or obese, and that more than a third are obese.
Obesity is a major public health concern because it predisposes the individual to many disorders, such as non-insulin-dependent diabetes, hypertension, stroke, and coronary disease. It has been associated with an increased incidence of certain cancers, notably cancers of the colon, rectum, prostrate, breast, uterus and cervix. Obese people are often ostracized, and discrimination against them, especially in hiring and promotion, is common.

Obesity research has shown a number of underlying causes of the condition. The simple cause is ingestion of more calories than are required for energy; the excess being stored in the body as fat. Inactivity and insufficient exercise can be contributing factors; the less active the person, the fewer calories are needed to maintain normal body weight. Another cause is overeating which may result from unhealthy patterns of eating established by the family and cultural environment. This may perhaps be exacerbated by psychological distress, an emotional dependence on food, or the omnipresence of high-calorie foods.

In some cases, obesity can come from an eating disorder. It has been shown, for example, that alcoholism for some people releases natural opiates in the brain, providing a

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sense of well-being and physical pleasure. Other studies have found a strong relationship between obesity in women and childhood sexual abuse.

Some weight-loss experts see obesity as based upon genetics and physiology. For example, rat studies have shown that fat cells secrete a hormone that helps the rat's brain assess the amount of body fat present. The brain tries to keep the amount of that hormone (which also appears to act on the brain area that regulates appetite and metabolic rate) at sea level, resulting in the so-called set point—a weight that the body comes back to, even after resolute dieting. The gene that encodes this hormone has been isolated in both rats and humans. In addition, a gene that influences obesity and the onset of diabetes has been identified. It has been estimated that from 8 to 30 different genes may influence obesity.

Radical treatments for weight loss have included wiring shut the jaw, operations that reduce the size of the stomach, and intestinal bypass operations circumventing a large area of the small intestine. Drugs to treat the condition now include orlistat (Xenical), which acts to block absorption of dietary fat in the intestines. The main possibility of treating obesity, however, remains diet and exercise, often coupled with emotional and behavioral support. The long-term weight-loss success of most attempts at dieting, however, is notoriously low. Groups such as Overeaters Anonymous, modeled after Alcoholics Anonymous, give support to people with weight problems and eating disorders.

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